

So and so that

Learner workbook

Distinguish a result from an intended purpose.

Understand the distinction

So commonly introduces a result: I was tired, so I went home. So that commonly introduces a purpose, often with can, could, will, or would: I wrote it down so that I could remember it.

That is sometimes omitted in informal purpose clauses: I wrote it down so I could remember. Use context to decide the meaning. In order to takes a base verb; in order that takes a clause and is more formal. A purpose does not guarantee success.

Compare the patterns

RESULT

The train stopped, so we got off.

Getting off followed the stop.

PURPOSE

I left early so that I could find a seat.

Finding a seat was the goal.

INFINITIVE

I left early in order to find a seat.

The same purpose uses to + verb.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Result or purpose: I spoke slowly so that everyone could follow?

2. Correct this: I called in order to that I could ask.

3. Does left early so that I could get a seat prove I got one?

Use it in your own life

Write a purpose sentence and a separate sentence giving the actual result.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. Purpose.

The speaker intended to help understanding.

2. I called so that I could ask.

Alternatively: I called in order to ask.

3. No. It states a purpose.

The intended result may not have happened.

One possible response

I left early so that I could catch the bus. It was full, so I waited for the next one.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-30.html